

PTI

OUT, FOR NOW
TDP chief N. Chandrababu Naidu walks out of jail after gettting interim bail, Oct. 31

ANDHRA PRADESH/ TDP

NAIDU'S SHIFT IN STRATEGY

Aware of its inability to pose a stiff challenge on its own, the TDP has already reached an understanding with actor-politician Pawan Kalyan's Jana Sena Party (JSP) for a united battle against the YSRCP. Naidu has always run the TDP as a one-man show, with second-rung leaders relegated to a marginal role. Even Naidu's son Lokesh, who has been getting projected as his successor since being made the party's national general secretary in 2014, has had a limited impact.

The main plan, say TDP insiders, is to rely on Bhuvaneswari to keep the middle-rung leaders and party cadre together in Naidu's absence. But political analysts point out that while she may evoke sympathy, her presence may fail to give the much-needed fillip to the party. "The TDP accounted for about a 40 per cent vote share [in 2019]," says political analyst D. Subramanyam Reddy. "It will decline if Naidu remains away from the public eye."

E. Venkatesu, a political scientist at the University of Hyderabad, too, believes that the people's response to Bhuvaneswari could be muted, given Jagan Reddy's "sophisticated information network" at the grassroots level.

But Naidu has the reputation of being a skilful survivor. Earlier, playing the victim card, he had shot off a letter to the special judge of the Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB) court to seek "foolproof security", alleging a "threat to his life" in jail. He has also decided against the TDP contesting the Telangana assembly poll, where the JSP has an electoral understanding with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), and to instead focus on Andhra Pradesh alone. "The district coordination committees [of the TDP-JSP alliance] will come up with action plans based on local inputs," says TDP state president K. Atchannaidu, "which would be consolidated at the state level in due course."

THE TDP IS BANKING ON SYMPATHY FOR NAIDU AND ALLIANCE WITH PAWAN KALYAN'S JSP TO TAKE ON CM JAGAN REDDY

On his part, Jagan Reddy is determined to position himself as the champion of the marginalised sections, who are being showered with a slew of sops. Within hours of Bhuvaneswari kicking off her yatra, the YSRCP flagged off the 'samajika sadhikara', or social empowerment, yatra to reach out to voters in all 175 constituencies by December-end. Together, these yatras are expected to set the agenda for the upcoming elections. Further developments in the corruption cases against Naidu will only add to the drama. ■